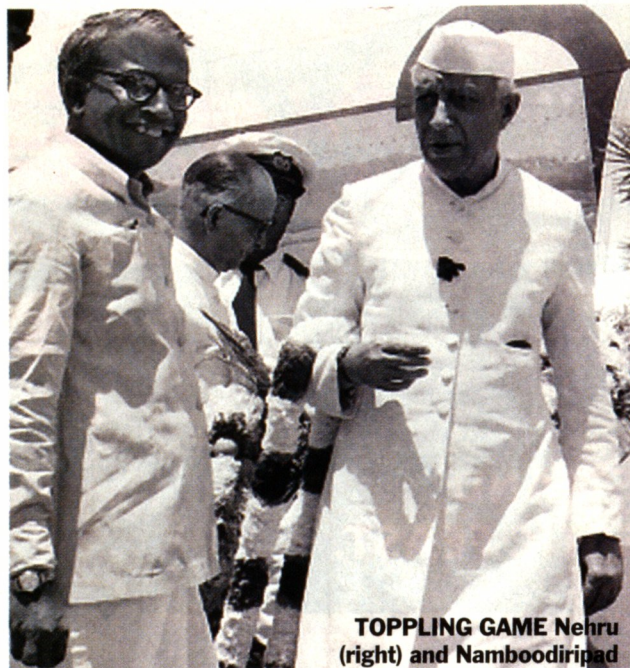


## THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Communists love conspiracy theories, especially about Americans. Forty-nine years after the world's first democratically elected communist government was toppled in Kerala, Marxists in the state are on a "whodunnit" mission. Thomas Isaac, state finance minister and a CPI(M) Central Committee member, returned from a US tour recently with what he calls "irrefutable evidence" to prove the CIA's role in funding the Congress party, the Church and other religious and caste organisations. This, he claims, was aimed at bringing down the E.M.S. Namboodiripad government in 1959.

Though charges of the CIA hand have been around for long, they won some endorsement in the late 1970s from Daniel Patrick Moynihan, former US ambassador to India, who in his memoirs wrote

## Marxist On a Mission



**TOPPLING GAME** Nehru (right) and Namboodiripad

that Indira Gandhi, then Congress president had on two occasions received substantial funds from US agencies including the CIA. Now Isaac claims to have collected from the Oral History Archives of the

Columbia University a copy of an interview given by Ellsworth Bunker who was US ambassador to India during 1957-59 when the shortlived government was sworn in and then dismissed.

Bunker is quoted as saying, "It's a fact that we did give the Congress party financial assistance because we knew the Russians were putting money into the Communist Party." Though Isaac spares none, he need not have any fears of retribution since nearly all those he names as conspirators are long dead—Pandit Nehru, Indira Gandhi, S.K. Patil, Dwight Eisenhower, CIA chief Allan Dulles and many others.

It is still not known whether Isaac's voyage of discovery was aimed at personal enlightenment or whipping up public passions over a 50-year-old "injustice". In an age when a government is only as good as its last good deed, Isaac's revelations are not likely to pay dividends for the Marxist-led LDF Government in Kerala, one of the most unpopular in recent times.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan

## THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

So confident was the Congress high command of the party's victory in Karnataka that a senior PMO functionary began interviewing some babus in order to identify a private secretary for the new chief minister.

## VOICES



"Our growth is at an impressive rate, but the pace of inclusiveness of growth is at a very tiny rate. We get weary easily, we have to work hard for it."

P. Chidambaram, finance minister

"The BJP's win in Karnataka should convince the Congress of the hollowness of politics of dharnas and empty slogans, bereft of ideology and commitment to the people."

Parkash Singh Badal, Punjab chief minister

"Has any country said that they will have no further nuclear tests? Has the US given any such undertaking? Has any other country said it in writing?"

L.K. Advani, leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha

"The time has come to throw out the UPA Government. The nation perhaps needs a second phase of independence struggle."

Gurudas Dasgupta, CPI leader

"Music is like water and air; it has no religion. It connects the world."

Salman Ahmad, Pakistani band Junoon's singer

